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August 20, 2025

Human Rights Group Sues Tesla for Greenwashing and Consumer Deception

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WASHINGTON, D.C. — International Rights Advocates (IRAdvocates) filed a lawsuit today against Tesla, Inc., accusing the company of deceiving consumers about the ethics and sustainability of its supply chain.

While Tesla promotes itself as an environmentally conscious and socially responsible leader in electric vehicles, the lawsuit alleges that the company relies on cobalt from suppliers deeply implicated in **forced labor, corruption, and widespread environmental destruction in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC)**.

“Tesla has built its brand on ethics and sustainability, but behind the glossy ads are supply chains drenched in abuse,” said **Terry Collingsworth, Executive Director of IRAdvocates**. “Consumers have a right to know the truth and Tesla must be held accountable for profiting from deception.”

A Pattern of Abuse in Tesla’s Supply Chain

According to the complaint, Tesla purchases cobalt from **Glencore**, one of the world’s most notorious mining companies. Glencore has faced criminal convictions in both the United States and Switzerland for bribery and money laundering. In the DRC, Glencore’s workers report exhausting shifts with little food or water and meager pay. Local communities have suffered from poisoned air, water, and farmland. Security forces contracted by Glencore have been accused of **shooting, torturing, and killing residents** suspected — often wrongly — of artisanal mining.

Tesla also relies on **Huayou Cobalt**, a Chinese multinational whose subsidiary, Congo Dongfang International Mining SARL (CDM), operates artisanal mines and sources from large industrial projects such as Sicomines and Tenke Fungurume Mining (TFM). These mines are notorious for **forced labor, physical abuse of workers, and violent**

evictions. In 2024, TFM displaced approximately 2,500 residents living near its operations after pollution from its facilities killed dozens.

Despite this record, Huayou blends cobalt from these suppliers during refining, funneling it directly into Tesla's supply chain.

Tesla's False Promises

Tesla has repeatedly assured consumers that it has “*zero tolerance*” for forced labor and that it prioritizes sustainability and ethical sourcing. Its public statements and branding — from Elon Musk's founding mission to “*accelerate the transition to sustainable energy*” to Tesla's annual reports — emphasize clean energy and respect for human rights.

Yet the reality exposed in the lawsuit paints a starkly different picture: **Tesla continues to profit from supply chains steeped in human suffering and ecological devastation.**

“Tesla has not only failed to live up to its promises it has actively misled consumers,” said Collingsworth. “This case will show that green marketing cannot be a cover for grave human rights abuses.”

Legal Action

The case, filed under the **D.C. Consumer Protection Procedures Act (CPPA)**, argues that Tesla's public claims amount to deceptive and unfair business practices. The Act allows consumers to hold companies accountable for misrepresentations and misleading conduct, particularly when those misrepresentations impact the choices of consumers in the District of Columbia.

IRAdvocates has used consumer protection law in past landmark cases to confront corporate abuses, and now seeks to bring Tesla to account for its role in sustaining exploitative supply chains while profiting from an image of responsibility and innovation.

Call to Action

IRAdvocates encourages consumers and concerned citizens to learn more about the case at www.internationalrightsadvocates.org.

“This lawsuit is about more than one company though,” Collingsworth added. **“It’s about ensuring that companies cannot lie to the public while enabling violence**

and exploitation abroad. If Tesla wants to be a true leader in sustainability, it must face the reality of its supply chain and change course.”